Module 10: Migration, Labor, and the Economy

Signature Learning Experience

Purpose

A design challenge: teams develop a realistic livelihood intervention for a specific migrant population in a specific place — grounded in evidence about what actually improves economic outcomes, honest about constraints like work authorization, credential recognition, and exploitation risk.

Aligned learning outcomes

- Describe the population's current labor market position (UG 1)
- Identify their economic contributions and constraints (UG 2)
- Explain the challenges — legal, financial, social — that the design must address (UG 3)
- Recognize exploitation risks and build safeguards into the design (UG 4)

Graduate extension

Graduate students add an evaluation framework: theory of change, measurable indicators, comparison logic, and a funder-style two-page executive summary — turning the design into a fundable proposal (Grad 1–2).

Assignment steps

1. In teams, choose a population and place (e.g., resettled refugees in a mid-size US city; Venezuelan professionals in Bogotá facing credential barriers; migrant women in informal domestic work; newcomer youth aging out of school support).
2. Diagnose the binding constraint: research what most limits this group's livelihoods — not what's most visible, what's most binding.
3. Review evidence on what works: ILO and World Bank livelihood studies, RCT evidence from IRC/J-PAL, documented program models (credential fast-tracking, microenterprise, worker co-ops, sector-based training).
4. Design the intervention: who it serves, what it does, who runs it, what it costs roughly, and how it avoids known failure modes (creaming, dependency, displacement of other workers).
5. Name the exploitation risks in your chosen sector and show the specific safeguards in the design.
6. Pitch the design to the class in ten minutes; the class plays skeptical funders. Revise once and submit.

Deliverables & format

- Design document, 2,000–2,500 words per team, with a one-page program logic diagram (graduate adds evaluation framework and executive summary)
- Evidence appendix: what works, with sources
- Pitch deck or one-pager used in the presentation

Grading rubric

Each criterion is scored at one of four levels, then weighted as shown. The overall grade is the weighted combination of criterion scores. Instructors may adapt weights and descriptors to local requirements.

Criterion (weight)	Exemplary (A)	Proficient (B)	Developing (C)	Beginning (D–F)
Sharpness of the constraint diagnosis 25%	Analysis is genuinely insightful: sharpness of the constraint diagnosis goes beyond summary to produce non-obvious, well-defended conclusions; concepts are applied accurately, complexity is preserved, and counterpoints are engaged seriously.	Analysis is competent: sharpness of the constraint diagnosis is achieved with clear reasoning and accurate use of course concepts, though conclusions stay near the expected.	Analysis is thin: sharpness of the constraint diagnosis is attempted but leans on summary or assertion; concepts are named more than used, and complications are avoided.	Analysis is absent: sharpness of the constraint diagnosis is not achieved; the work describes without analyzing or draws conclusions its own material does not support.
Evidence base — design choices traced to what works 30%	Evidence and accuracy are exemplary: evidence base — design choices traced to what works is met with high-quality, correctly cited sources for every substantive claim; terms, facts, and frameworks are used precisely.	Evidence and accuracy are solid: evidence base — design choices traced to what works is met for nearly all claims, with only minor sourcing gaps or imprecisions that do not affect conclusions.	Evidence and accuracy are uneven: evidence base — design choices traced to what works is partly met — some claims lack support, sources are thin or misread, or terms are used loosely in ways that weaken conclusions.	Evidence and accuracy are deficient: evidence base — design choices traced to what works is not met; key claims are unsupported or wrong, and errors undermine the work's conclusions.
Realism: costs, operators, failure modes, safeguards 25%	Design judgment is excellent: realism: costs, operators, failure modes, safeguards is fully addressed — costs, constraints, politics, and failure modes are named honestly and the proposal remains workable anyway.	Design judgment is good: realism: costs, operators, failure modes, safeguards is addressed for the major factors, with minor blind spots that would not sink the proposal.	Design judgment is limited: realism: costs, operators, failure modes, safeguards is addressed superficially — key constraints or failure modes are ignored, making the proposal fragile.	Design judgment is missing: realism: costs, operators, failure modes, safeguards is not addressed; the proposal ignores obvious constraints and would not survive contact with reality.

Criterion (weight)	Exemplary (A)	Proficient (B)	Developing (C)	Beginning (D–F)
Pitch quality and team response to challenge questions 20%	Performance under questioning is outstanding: pitch quality and team response to challenge questions shows command of the material, direct engagement with hard questions, and revision that visibly improved the work.	Performance is solid: pitch quality and team response to challenge questions shows good command and reasonable answers to challenges, with revision addressing the main feedback.	Performance is shaky: pitch quality and team response to challenge questions shows incomplete command — questions deflected or answered vaguely, revision cosmetic.	Performance is inadequate: pitch quality and team response to challenge questions shows the student could not explain or defend their own work, and feedback was not incorporated.